# Unit 6: Writing from visual data

Visual data refers to any method of representing information in a graphic form. Most writers choose to use visual data to summarize a large amount of information. Some examples of ways they do this is by using tables, graphs, or charts; these can be referred to collectively as figures. Visual data do *not* replace a written text. They go together.

In this unit, you will **write a report of about 300-400 words based on a given figure and related information**. The report should have **an introduction**, **discussion of the given figure**, and a **conclusion**.

1. **The introduction**

The introduction to your report should have a **location element**. This sentence, which is always in the present tense, directs the reader to the particular figure(s) that you are going to discuss. The sentence can be in either active voice:

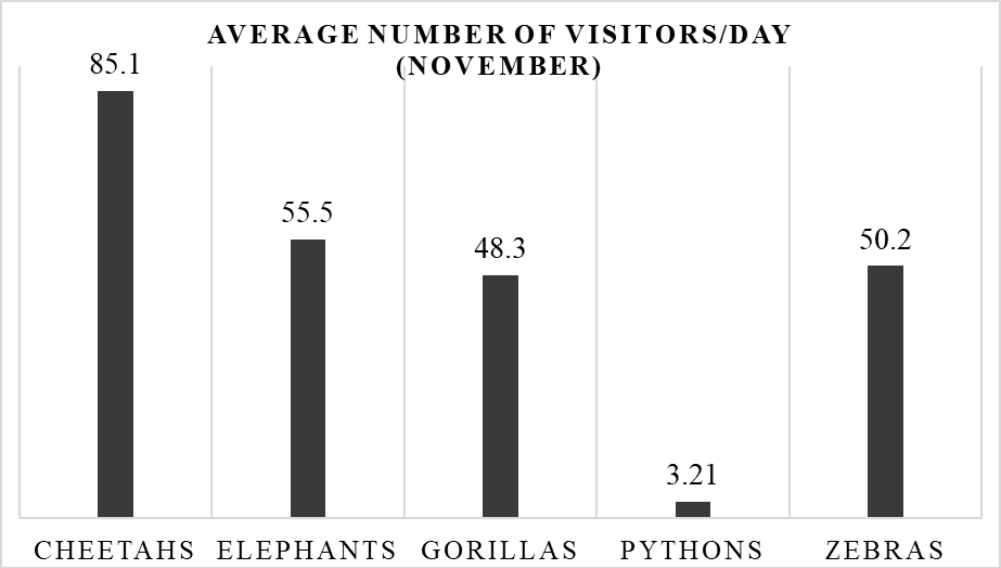
- Figure 5 presents the average number of visitors per day to five animal enclosures at Golden Zoo in the month of November.
- Fig. 6 shows the reasons that survey respondents avoided the python enclosure.

Or passive voice:

- The average number of visitors per day to five animal enclosures at Golden Zoo in November is presented in Figure 5.
- The reasons that survey respondents avoided the python enclosure are shown in Fig. 6.

**Exercise 1.** Label the following figures A and B as "Fig. 5" or "Fig. 6".

**A.** _____ Average number of visitors/day to five animal enclosures at Golden Zoo, November



**B.** _____ Reasons for avoidance of the python enclosure

| Reason | % of survey respondents who agreed |
|---|---|
| Too few pythons | 14.8 |
| Uninterested in pythons | 2.5% |
| Scared of pythons | 2.3% |
| Line in front of enclosure is too long | 53.6 |
| Distance from entrance is too far | 25.5 |

2. **Discussion of the figure**

When discussing the figure, first determine what its purpose is. Ask yourself:

- Why was that figure made?
- What questions does it answer?

**Exercise 2.** Answer the following questions by referring to the given figure (Fig. 1).

1. For which of the following purposes was this figure made?

A. To summarize why most visitors go to Golden Zoo

B. To point out problems visitors had with Golden Zoo

C. To compare the ages of visitors to Golden Zoo

D. To check the number of visitors to Golden Zoo

2. Which question can this figure NOT help answer?

A. Why do people visit Golden Zoo?

B. What do people do at Golden Zoo?

C. Which animals do people prefer at Golden Zoo?

D. Which activities are popular at Golden Zoo?

**Fig. 1.** Primary reasons for visiting Golden Zoo

| Purpose | % of visitors |
|---|---|
| Learn about animals | 75 |
| See unknown animals | 63.5 |
| Take selfies with animals | 33.5 |
| Create social media content | 33.4 |
| Relax with friends/family | 20.1 |

Once you have determined the figure's purpose, you should report the data and interpret them. This means you ask yourself: *What stands out or is interesting on the figure in relation to its purposes?*

You should report the data or results on the figure that answer the questions that led to the data being collected and any other interesting points, such as strange trends (e.g. one result that is much lower than the others, two results that are very similar, etc.).

When reporting the data, use past tense. This is because the data were collected and analyzed in the past. Look at how these data are reported. These all link to the purpose of the figure, which was to answer the question: *Which of five animal enclosures at Golden Zoo were most popular in November?* and *What were the top reasons for visitors' avoidance of the python enclosure?*

- Cheetahs were the most popular animal at the zoo in November. The average number of visitors to their enclosure each day was 85.1.
- Only a small number of people visited the pythons. As seen in the figure, the average number of visitors to their enclosure per day was 3.21.
- The three main reasons people did not visit the python enclosure were because the line was too long (53.6%), the enclosure was far from the entrance (25.5%), and there were too few pythons (14.8%).

  **Be sure to avoid starting sentences with numbers**. Rewrite any sentences that start with numbers by spelling them out as words (*Three cheetahs were in the enclosure, NOT 3 cheetahs were in the enclosure*), or using the first two techniques in the Writing skill: Writing from visual data box on p. 81 of your textbook.

When presenting your interpretation of the data, use either present tense and subjective language. This is because although these conclusions are based on data from the past, we hope that they are true for the present or going forward, but we cannot be sure. The actual data, however, should still be presented in past tense.

- Surprisingly, over a quarter of visitors said the reason why they did not want to visit the python enclosure was it was too far from the entrance. It is a problem that needs to be discussed.
- Only a little more than 2% of visitors said they lacked interest in or feared pythons, so it does not seem like a major problem for most visitors.

**3. A conclusion**

The final part of the your report is the conclusion. This is where you give your final summary of the data and where needed, make recommendations based on the data. Most of the same language use patterns apply. However, you can use both present tense and future tense for the conclusion, along with subjective language. Actual data should still be written in past tense.

- It is recommended that more pythons are added to the python enclosure, because 14.8% of visitors thought there were too few pythons.
- The zoo should advertise the pythons more frequently to raise interest in them and increase the number of visitors who visit their enclosure.

- If pythons wear cute hats or bows, visitors will likely feel less afraid of them.

**Exercise 3.** The following report is based on these directions. Read the report and do the tasks that follow.

**Directions**: You work for Golden Zoo, which is a popular tourist destination in one Canadian province. The management team at the zoo has decided they want to determine why people are visiting the zoo. They want to know what they should do to make visits better. The team asked you to conduct a survey to find out the primary reasons visitors have for coming to the zoo. Your survey led to the results in Figure 1.

Write a 300-400 word report that summarizes all the results, interprets at least two of the results, and gives two recommendations based on the data.

**Fig. 1.** Primary reasons for visiting Golden Zoo

| Purpose | % of visitors |
|---|---|
| Learn about animals | 75 |
| See unknown animals | 63.5 |
| Take selfies with animals | 33.5 |
| Create social media content | 33.4 |
| Relax with friends/family | 20.1 |

**Report on Golden Zoo visitors**

The purpose of this report is to present the main reasons visitors have for coming to Golden Zoo, a popular Canadian tourist destination. The report is based on the results from a survey of zoo visitors. Fig. 1. shows the top five reasons that respondents gave for visiting Golden Zoo.

As can be seen in the figure, the primary reason that visitors chose to visit the zoo was to learn about animals. Seventy-five percent of the respondents said this was their main motivation to come to the zoo. The second major reason why people visit the zoo was to see unknown animals. What is positive about these two primary reasons is that these are also two major goals of all zoos. Zoos want to give people education on animals that they are familiar with, but also introduce them to new or unknown animals. It is good that people's reasons for visiting Golden Zoo are the same as its goals. The next two reasons for visiting the zoo were cited by about nearly the same percentage of visitors: take selfies with animals (33.5%) and create social media content (33.4%). The very small difference might be because the two activities can be done together. Therefore, some visitors may decide to go the zoo to both take selfies and create social media. As a result, the percentage of visitors with this reason for going to the zoo is almost identical. The final purpose that people had for visiting the zoo was to relax with friends or family. A little more than one in five visitors said they went to the zoo to do this.

In conclusion, Golden Zoo visitors had five main purposes for going to the zoo. It is suggested that informative pamphlets be given to all visitors when they come to the zoo, because the top reason

most people visited was to be educated on animals. Additionally, more than one-third of visitors came to the zoo for the purpose of taking selfies or making social media content. What this means is that the zoo should set up locations where visitors can easily take photographs and videos of the animals. Implementation of these recommendations will improve visits to Golden Zoo.

1. Identify the location element.

2. Identify at least two examples of results being interpreted.

3. Identify the recommendations given in the report, and the results that support them.